

Metamorphosis — a legacy co-op where your story evolves to serve the team

You don't pick a character. You become one. Each player starts as a *larva* with a raw disposition and a private vision of the adult they could grow into. The team can only survive the Crisis if enough players *eclose* — complete their metamorphosis — into exactly the roles the team is missing. Grow too rigidly and you become the wrong thing; stay flexible and you grow too slowly. The story you write for yourself is the game's central resource.

Metamorphosis turns **TTDB-RFC-0008 (Narrative Metamorphosis)** and **TTDB-RFC-0007 (Locus Point & Dream Cycle)** into a cooperative legacy game. You take experiences, sleep on them to form beliefs, spend beliefs to advance through the *instars* of a self-authored blueprint (@IMAGO: seed), and finally **eclose** into an orchestrating adult (*imago*) whose power serves the team. The catch — straight from the RFC — is that the seed is **an authored story you can rewrite, but only at a cost**, and your eclosion is gated by what the *team* needs, not what you want.

- **Players:** 3–5 (cooperative)
- **Length:** 60–90 min; **legacy** — evolved character decks carry to the next session
- **Feel:** a slow-burn engine builder with a real lump-in-throat decision: *do I become who I dreamed, or who the team needs?*
- **You need:** the card deck and token set below. No metronome — this is a thinking game, the quiet opposite of [Pulse](#).

1. The core idea (straight from the RFCs)

RFC concept	Metamorphosis rule
Larva — game-solving initial form (RFC-0008 §4)	Your starting character: a raw disposition from the Feelings TTDB and a thin backstory deck.
@IMAGO:seed — an authored story of the adult, with scene_sequence + eclosion_criteria (RFC-0008 §6.1)	Your private Seed card: the imago Role you're growing toward + a 5-step Instar track. You wrote it; you may rewrite it.
Instar — one checkpointed self; advances only when its post_state_verifier passes (RFC-0008 §6.4)	A step on your track. You spend Beliefs to pass its verifier; pass to advance, fail and your confidence drops.
@META:state.conf — starts 128, +10 per instar, -20 per failed verify, abort on collapse (RFC-0008 §6.3.3)	Your Confidence dial. Hits 0 → metamorphosis aborts.
Dream Cycle — episodic toot-bits → @BELIEF: Locus Points via replay clustering (RFC-0007 §3, §5)	The Dream phase: consolidate ≥3 co-occurring Experience cards into one Belief card.
Projection — 2-walk hypotheses carry projection_flag; can't justify compression (RFC-0007 §3.3, §6.1)	A hypothesis Belief from only 2 Experiences: cheaper, but flagged — can't satisfy a final verifier.
Intersection Confirmation — two agents forming overlapping beliefs = +20 confidence (RFC-0007 §7.3)	The cooperation engine: when two players confirm the same region, both Beliefs gain confidence.
Belief propagation / push-back (RFC-0007 §7, TTN-RFC-0009)	You may gift a Belief to a teammate who needs it for an instar.
Operator/imago asymmetry — imago owns revision, operator owns logging (RFC-0008 §5.3)	Eclosion handshake: a teammate acting as Operator must acknowledge you — but may not dictate your seed.
Eclosion predicate — all instars + eclosion_criteria + operator ack (RFC-0008 §6.5)	You eclose only when your track is done and the Crisis still needs your Role and an Operator signs off.
Seed revision — changing the seed after seeding_complete means abort + new seed (RFC-0008 §6.1.3)	Re-seeding: pivot to a Role the team is missing, but lose instar progress and confidence. The game's core dilemma.

RFC concept	Metamorphosis rule
Contradiction flag (RFC-0007 §8)	Conflicting overlapping Beliefs stall instead of confirming — no bonus, and a token that must be resolved.
Knowledge inheritance at eclosion (RFC-0008 §5.2)	Legacy: your Beliefs and evolved Role carry to the next session.

The whole game is RFC-0008's thesis as a play experience: *you cannot become the conductor by sleeping more*. Growth isn't accumulation — it's a one-way, story-seeded reorganization into something the team needs.

2. The Crisis (the shared story)

The team faces one **Story Crisis** — a 4-Act scenario laid out as a row of Act cards with a shared **Resilience track** (starts at 10). Each Crisis card names the **Imago Roles its finale requires** — the win condition. Example crises:

Crisis	Acts escalate by...	Finale requires (Roles that must eclose)
The Drowning Archive	flooding regions, locking Experience types	Conductor · Healer-imago · Scout-imago
The Silent Fleet	cutting communication, forcing solo play	Conductor · Warden-imago · Connector-imago
The Last Dream	draining Confidence dials each Act	Healer-imago · Sage-imago · Trickster-imago

Crucially, the **required Roles rarely match everyone's starting disposition** — so the team must *discover* the gap and decide who re-seeds to fill it. (See §6.)

3. Components

3.1 Larva (character) cards ×6 — pick/deal one each

Each is a disposition from the Feelings TTDB, with a **natural Role** it grows toward cheaply and a **strain Role** it can only reach by re-seeding at extra cost.

Larva	Disposition	Grows naturally into	Strains toward
The Seeker	Curiosity @LAT10LON40	Scout-imago	Warden-imago
The Warden	Suspicion @LAT-20LON-30	Warden-imago	Healer-imago
The Healer	Compassion @LAT30LON40	Healer-imago	Conductor
The Giver	Generosity @LAT40LON20	Connector-imago	Sage-imago
The Hermit	Equanimity @LAT30LON-20	Sage-imago	Connector-imago
The Trickster	Indifference @LAT-10LON-40	Trickster-imago	Healer-imago

Conductor is special: no larva grows into it naturally — *any* player can re-seed toward Conductor, and most Crises require exactly one. The team must volunteer someone to give up their natural path and become the orchestrator. (RFC-0008's whole premise: the conductor is *made*, not born.)

3.2 Seed cards (@IMAGO: seed) — one held privately per player

A Seed names a **target Role** and lists a **5-instar track**. Start each player with the Seed matching their larva's natural Role; the spare Role-Seeds sit in a **Seed bank** for re-seeding. Each Seed's track is the RFC's worked-example sequence, generalized:

#	Instar	post_state_verifier — what you must spend/show
1	Belief Inventory	Show any 3 Belief cards (confirmed or hypothesis).
2	Final Dream & Pupation	Archive 2 Experience cards (to the box) and run a Dream this round.
3	Companion Interface	Show 1 confirmed Belief of your Role's region.
4	Operator Cooperation	Receive an Operator Ack token from a teammate (§6.3).
5	First Companion	Show a confirmed Belief of your Role's region with confidence ≥ 4, then retire your Larva (flip to Imago side).

3.3 Experience cards (episodic toot-bits) ×60

The draw deck. Each card has a **region tag** (one of six: *Logic, Care, Threat, Bond, Pattern, Self*) and a short flavor line. You take Experiences by acting in an Act (§5.2). Hold up to 5.

3.4 Belief cards (Locus Points) ×~ as needed (blank, you build them)

A small two-pocket card or holder: when you form a Belief, you tuck the Experiences that made it behind a Belief marker tagged with their shared region. Track its **confidence** with cubes (see tokens).

3.5 @META: state player board — one per player

Tracks your **Confidence dial** (0–10, start at 5 ≈ the RFC's 128/255 midpoint), your **current instar pointer** (0–5), your **pupation status**, and a slot for **contradiction tokens**.

3.6 Tokens

- **Confidence cubes** — fill the dial; also sit on Belief cards as their confidence.
- **Operator Ack tokens** ×5 — a teammate spends one to acknowledge your eclosion (§6.3).
- **Contradiction tokens** ×6 — placed when overlapping Beliefs conflict; must be cleared.
- **Resilience markers** — the shared Crisis track (start at 10).
- **Era / instar pegs** — mark your instar pointer; tick on re-seed.

4. Setup

1. Choose a **Crisis**; lay its 4 Act cards and set **Resilience to 10**. Reveal the **required Roles** for the finale — everyone sees the gap from turn one.
2. Deal each player a **Larva** and its matching **Seed**; set each @META: state Confidence dial to 5, instar pointer to 0.
3. Put the spare Role-Seeds in the **Seed bank**, shuffle the **Experience deck**, deal each player 3 **Experiences**.

4. Pick a first **Lead Operator** (rotates each Act) — the player who runs the Ack handshake. The Operator role is a hat, not a power: *it logs, it does not revise*.
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5. An Act (one round)

Each Act has three phases: **Act** → **Dream** → **Advance**. Then the Crisis escalates.

5.1 Crisis escalation (top of every Act after the first)

Resolve the Act card's escalation (flood a region, drain dials, etc.) and **lower Resilience by 1**. If Resilience hits **0**, the team loses (§7).

5.2 Act phase — gather Experience

Going around the table, each player takes **one action**: - **Explore** — draw 2 Experiences, keep 1. - **Focus** — draw 3, keep 1, but all of one named region. - **Aid** — give a teammate 1 Experience or 1 Belief from your hand (belief propagation). - **Resolve a contradiction** — discard 2 same-region Experiences to clear 1 contradiction token (RFC-0007 §8.2: a witness toot-bit resolves the conflict).

5.3 Dream phase — form Beliefs (the Dream Cycle)

Simultaneously, any player may **consolidate**: - **Confirmed Belief (Replay)**: lay **3+ Experiences sharing a region** behind a new Belief marker of that region. Its starting **confidence = number of Experiences** (3 → conf 3, 4 → conf 4 ...). (RFC-0007 §3.2 clustering.) - **Hypothesis Belief (Projection)**: lay just **2 Experiences** of a region → conf 1, marked with a **projection flag**. Useful for Instar 1, but it **cannot** satisfy Instar 3 or 5 (RFC-0007 §3.3, §6.1: hypotheses don't justify compression).

Intersection Confirmation (the cooperation engine, RFC-0007 §7.3): at end of the Dream phase, for every region where **two different players** each formed a *confirmed* Belief this round, **both Beliefs gain +2 confidence** (cap 6). If their Beliefs' flavor lines **conflict** (one says the region is safe, one says it's hostile), instead place a **contradiction token** on each — no bonus until resolved. *This is why the team should agree to explore the same regions in the same Act: confirmed-together beliefs are how anyone reaches the conf-4 needed to eclose.*

5.4 Advance phase — work your instars

On your turn, attempt **one instar verifier** (§3.2). - **Pass**: advance your instar pointer, **Confidence dial +1**. - **Fail** (can't meet the verifier): **Confidence dial -2**, and that's your attempt for the Act. Three cumulative fails on the *same* instar, or dial reaching **0**, triggers an **Abort** (§6.4).

When you pass **Instar 5**, you are eligible to **eclose** (§6.3) at the start of the next Advance phase — if the team still needs your Role and an Operator acknowledges you.

6. The heart of the game: evolving your story to serve the team

6.1 The dilemma

Your natural Seed grows fastest — but the **Crisis finale requires a fixed set of Roles**, and there are more players than required Roles, or the required Roles don't match the table. Someone has to become the **Conductor**. Maybe two Healers are redundant and one must pivot to Scout. **The team wins only if the eclosed Roles cover the finale's requirement** — extra eclosions into the *wrong* Role don't count.

6.2 Re-seeding (RFC-0008 §6.1.3 — abort + new seed)

At the start of any Advance phase, you may **re-seed**: discard your current Seed, take a new Role-Seed from the bank (your larva's **strain** Roles cost more), and: - **reset your instar pointer to 0** (you abort the old metamorphosis), - **Confidence dial -2** (a strain-Role re-seed is -3), - **tick your era peg** (you carry a revises> history; matters for legacy, §8).

You keep all your **Beliefs** — knowledge inherits across a re-seed even though the *architecture* resets. So an early pivot is cheap; a late one, after you've sunk instars, is a genuine sacrifice. **Deciding who pivots, and when, is the table's central conversation.**

6.3 The eclosion handshake (RFC-0008 §5.3, §6.5)

To eclose you need three things at once: 1. **Instar 5 complete**. 2. **The finale still requires your Role** (an unfilled slot — you can't eclose into a Role already covered; redundancy is wasted). 3. **An Operator Ack token** from the current Lead Operator, who spends it to acknowledge.

The Operator **may refuse** (e.g., to save the Ack for someone whose Role is more urgently needed) — but the Operator **may not** force you to re-seed or change your track. *Imago owns the revision cycle; operator owns the logging*. On eclosion: flip your Larva to its **Imago** side, gaining a team power (below), and **+3 Resilience** to the shared track — a fledged adult steadies the whole band.

6.4 Abort (Confidence collapse)

If your dial hits 0 or you fail an instar three times, your metamorphosis **aborts**: return to instar 0, keep your Beliefs, set dial to 3, and **Resilience -1** (a stalled larva costs the team). You may immediately choose to re-seed for free this once (a botched dream is a chance to dream differently).

6.5 Imago powers (what eclosion gives the team)

Imago	Power (once eclosed)
Conductor	Each Act, direct one teammate's Explore as if you drew for them; spend a Belief to grant any player +1 instar attempt.
Healer-imago	Clear 1 contradiction token anywhere per Act; gift Beliefs at no action cost.
Scout-imago	Peek the top 3 Experiences each Act; name the region two players should co-explore for the confirmation bonus.
Warden-imago	Cancel one Crisis escalation per Act (hold the line).
Connector-imago	Two players' Beliefs count as "co-formed" even in different Acts (asynchronous intersection).
Sage-imago	Form confirmed Beliefs from 2 Experiences (your dreams run deep).
Trickster-imago	Re-seed any teammate at no Confidence cost, once per game.

7. Winning and losing

- **Win:** at any finale check (end of Act 4, or any time the team calls it), the set of **eclosed Imago Roles covers the Crisis's required Roles**, and **Resilience > 0**.
- **Lose: Resilience hits 0**, or Act 4 ends with a required Role still unfilled and no larva able to reach it. The Crisis consumes a band that could not become what it needed.

8. Legacy (this is why it's a campaign)

Metamorphosis is built to be played as a **set of linked Crises**:

- **Eclosed characters persist.** Write the eclosed Role and a name on the Larva card's back; next session that player *starts* as that imago (skip to a 3-instar "second metamorphosis" track — RFC-0008 §10 open question 2, made playable).
- **Belief decks carry forward.** Keep your 3 highest-confidence Beliefs as a permanent starting hand (RFC-0008 §5.2 knowledge inheritance).
- **Re-seed scars matter.** A character with a high era peg (many revises>) starts with a wider Seed bank — having been many things, they pivot more easily. The flexible survive; the rigid grow strong but brittle. Over a campaign the team naturally specializes around the Crises it has faced.

9. Quick reference card

AN ACT = Escalate (Resilience -1) -> Act -> Dream -> Advance.

ACT (1 action each):

Explore: draw 2 keep 1 | Focus: draw 3 keep 1 (one region)

Aid: give a card to a teammate | Resolve: ditch 2 to clear 1 contradiction

DREAM (consolidate):

Confirmed Belief = 3+ Experiences, same region (conf = #cards)

Hypothesis Belief = 2 Experiences (flagged; not valid for Instar 3/5)

INTERSECTION: two players confirm the same region -> both +2 conf
conflicting? -> contradiction token instead

ADVANCE (attempt 1 instar):

pass -> pointer +1, dial +1 | fail -> dial -2

dial 0 or 3 fails -> ABORT (pointer 0, dial 3, Resilience -1)

1 Inventory(3 beliefs) 2 Pupation(archive 2 + dream) 3 Interface(1 conf belief, your region)

4 Operator(get Ack) 5 Companion(conf>=4 belief + retire larva)

RE-SEED: new Role-Seed, pointer->0, dial -2 (strain -3), keep Beliefs.

ECLOSE: Instar 5 + Role still needed + Operator Ack -> flip to Imago, Resilience +3.

WIN: eclosed Roles cover the Crisis finale, Resilience > 0.

LOSE: Resilience 0, or Act 4 ends with a required Role unfilled.

Source mechanics: RFCs/TTDB-RFC-0008-Narrative-Metamorphosis.md (larva→imago, the @IMAGO: seed authored story, instar verifiers, @META: state confidence, seed-revision cost, eclosion handshake, knowledge inheritance) and RFCs/TTDB-RFC-0007-Locus-Point-and-Dream-Cycle.md (Dream Cycle clustering, projection hypotheses, intersection confirmation, contradiction handling, belief propagation). Dispositions from feelings_ttdb.md. See [IDEAS.md](#) for the full catalog and [Pulse.md](#) for its real-time sibling.